

ECHOES AT THE EDGE





# ECHOS AT THE EDGE

*Lyric of the Emotional Threshold*



A poetry anthology  
The Inner Horizon

ÍÑIGO BARRERA BARCELÓ

Echoes at the Edge. Lyric of the Emotional Threshold

A poetry anthology from The Inner Horizon

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The twenty-one poems and the glossary come from the poetry section of The Inner Horizon and are

The illustrations come from the illustrated and chamber editions of the same work. They are listed

Set in Source Serif Pro.

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*To whoever stayed on the shore  
when the water withdrew.*



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## FROM THE SHORE

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This volume gathers the twenty-one poems and the glossary that close *The Inner Horizon*. In the complete work they appear interspersed between the essay and the stories, each one at the point where an idea stops being explainable and can only be said. Here they stand together, for the first time, and read straight through they tell a different story.

The argument of the book they come from fits in one sentence: consciousness might have the shape of a horizon, a boundary that separates an inside from an outside and that emerges from the same material everything else is made of. It is a hypothesis, and the essay defends it with the apparatus that befits one. The poems do not defend it. They do something else: they inhabit it. They ask what it feels like to stand inside a boundary like that, what hurts when it cracks, and what remains when the water on the other side recedes.

They are divided into three books, and the division follows temperature, not chronology.

**Book One**, *The Architecture with a Hollow*, is a mourning told in eight crafts and one small experiment. An archivist, a watchmaker, a luthier, a song someone used to hum in the kitchen, and, opening the book, a soap bubble held between two hands. None of the nine speaks of loss directly: they speak of what the hands keep doing while the loss happens. The hollow in the title is not a metaphor for emptiness. It is what makes a violin's body sound.

**Book Two**, *The Coldness of a Darkened City*, lowers the temperature. Six poems of urban winter, written from inside a body that never quite warms up: the subway, the pill on the table,

a carol that fools no one, a fogged window with Barcelona behind it. It is the roughest part of the collection, and the one that consoles the least.

**Book Three**, *The Last Books*, gathers six poems that had already been told in prose in the work's final movements — the time that does not pass, the mirror without depth, the invisible tuning fork, the eye of a single color, fractal reality — and returns them to verse, which was probably their native language.

The volume closes with an *Intimate Glossary*: the essay's technical words — horizon, interface, entanglement, reservoir — redefined as what they had actually meant all along.

Each poem opens on an odd-numbered page, facing its illustration. The plates come from the work's illustrated and chamber editions, and are listed one by one at the end, in case anyone wants to know what they were looking at.

You do not need to have read *The Inner Horizon* to read this. At most, you need to have once stood on a shore watching the water leave, not knowing if it would return, and not knowing what it might bring back.





BOOK ONE

# The Architecture with a Hollow

---

*Nine ways into a mourning: what remains when the water recedes  
and you have to keep measuring the shore.*



## The Bubble

---

The soap stretches in my hands,  
it curves.

Suddenly, I form a sphere:  
an inside and an outside  
that did not exist before.

The horizon is not the line I seek on the map.  
It is the living boundary  
that I feel on my own skin.

I am the sum of the orchestra  
that is in no single musician.

I am the void that, as it collapses,  
creates something like a star.

The water recedes.  
I do not tear away,  
I say goodbye.



## The Archivist

---

The water left the way  
polite guests leave:  
by night,  
leaving the room ready  
for someone I do not know.

I recorded the first strip of mud  
in the handwriting of normal days.  
There are hands that do not know  
they are writing a farewell.

The children show their blisters  
like coins from a country  
that does not yet exist.

I leave holes in the notebook.  
And at night, asleep,  
I still row.



## The Watchmaker

---

Two hours a day  
someone cleans the glass.

I open the silver watch  
with the pulse from before,  
that returns for a visit  
and does not take off its coat.

The balance wheel does its work:  
tick, tock, tick.  
I listen to it as one listens to  
another's heart:  
grateful that it is not mine  
that keeps the count.

When the morning begins to thicken  
I know it before my fingers do.  
I put away the tools  
in the exact order  
I want to find them  
if tomorrow opens.



## The Luthier

---

I have never entered a box  
of the ones I tune.  
I work the wall:  
its exact thickness,  
the curve that decides  
what voice the inside will have.

They bring me cracks  
wrapped in wool sweaters.  
I close them without covering them.  
I charge for the honesty  
of the line that remains.

And when the bus passes,  
the whole shop responds:  
each wood with its note,  
none with mine.



## Montse XX

---

Montse is the face of a horizon I did not know I had.

Our hands find each other  
and something opens that has no name.

I carried a hollow.  
She carried a light that did not come down from above,  
but was born of being here,  
and the cracks hurt less  
when someone ran their fingers over them.

Pure dance:  
two threads weave without losing themselves  
and a color is born that was not there before.

When the water was leaving, I thought it was ending.  
She taught me another word,  
that after the emptiness something new comes.

My chest has learned a rhythm it did not know,  
the one that sounds when two breaths find each other.

I see it every morning at dawn,  
her eyes open while the city still sleeps,  
my hand lost in her hair,  
a silence that has learned to stay.

And the craft of a whole life  
was only  
to discover that the hollow had  
the exact shape of your hand.



## The Oar

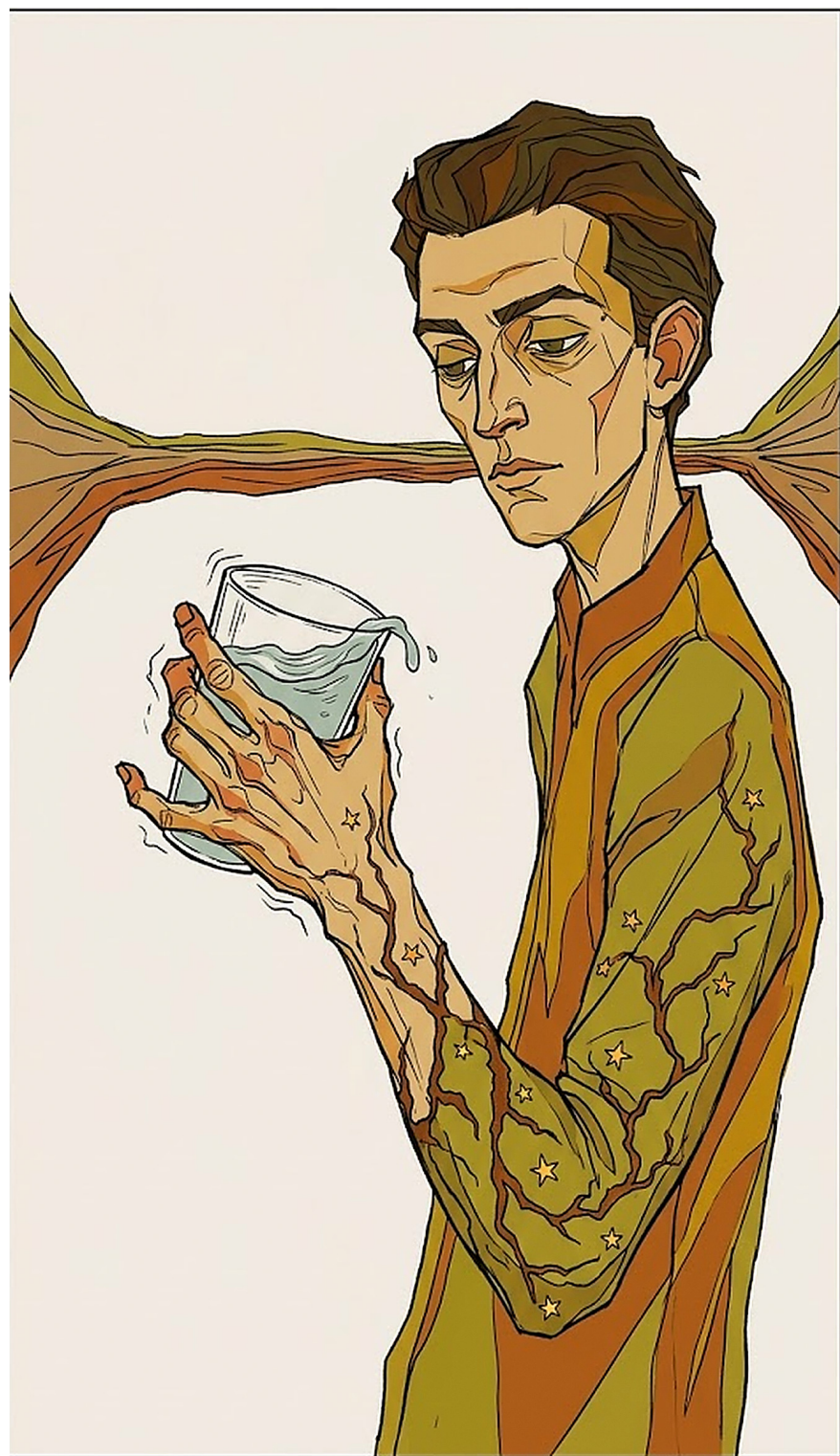
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The oar touched bottom  
where before there was a fathom.

I am not saying the water receded.  
I am saying the impact rose through my arm,  
settled in my wrist,  
and reminded me —with the ache of the tendons—  
that the void is not empty.

I have seen the horizon emerge from my own reservoir.  
I have seen it return.

Repetition, I learned, anchors more  
than understanding ever could.



## The Tremor

---

You asked me about the loyalty of matter  
and I, a coward, spoke to you of irretrievable information.

Forgive me.

I should have told you the truth:  
information persists in me,  
like the name of a street  
that no one pronounces anymore,  
but that I walk in dreams every night.

I learned to wait,  
seeing myself in the rust  
that takes possession of its own iron,  
unhurried, undisciplined.

Without rage.  
But with this certainty that weighs on me  
and aches in the center of my chest.

I have seen the horizon contract  
in the tremor of my own hand  
that no longer remembers  
how to hold a glass without fear of breaking it.



## The Shore

---

And the water returned to my shore  
without warning.

And I did not know  
—neither as archivist of my own cracks,  
nor as the boy I was—  
if the city I lost had returned  
or if it was another city,  
a colder one,  
with the same shore as always.

The water returned at night.  
No one knew if it brought anything.  
No one knew if it left anything in my house.

But at dawn,  
I looked at my hands  
open.

And I understood.  
Perhaps,  
that was the answer.



## The Song

---

Four notes:  
the one that rises, the one that falls,  
the silence,  
once again.

I do not know when I stored them.  
The body gathers without warning:  
a rhythm of sleeping breath,  
the precise force of a drawer,  
the warm hollow of the sofa.

Now I sing them,  
at the hour she used to cook,  
a little slower  
or the same:  
we never measured it.

The kitchen recognizes them.  
That is enough.  
Or it is not enough,  
but it sounds.







BOOK TWO

# The Coldness of a Darkened City

---

*A winter that never quite arrives and, even so, it's cold: six seasons  
of the body in a city that does not respond.*



## Cartography of the Echo

---

Inside, there is no heart.  
There is a noise.  
A small tremor, as if the body  
were trying to remember something it no longer knows.  
The skin separates nothing.  
It is an open place,  
a tired border  
where what I do not want enters  
and the little I still keep escapes.

The body is a borrowed space.  
A windowless room  
where the light enters late  
and leaves too soon.

Every gesture leaves a minimal trace:  
a chill,  
a weight,  
an absence.

With this I try to say, "I am still here."

And beneath the tongue, still,  
a coldness that does not leave.



## Song of Death

---

A key that opens nothing.  
A book open to a page  
I do not remember reading.  
The bed divided into two silences.

Nothing moves.  
Things wait,  
as if they knew no one is coming back.

A wine stain that is already part of the table.  
The light entering from the side,  
tracing the absence with cruel precision.

Memory does not disappear:  
it fills with other things,  
like a hollow in the earth  
gathering dark water.

Silence is a new organ.  
A muscle learning not to sound.

And I listen,  
in case inside the wood,  
or in the rotting fruit,  
there might be some answer.

In the end,  
an open hand.  
A little salt.  
And the wind doing what it can.



## Lament of the Return

---

I

The pact with the light is over.  
The week turns like an old door  
and I enter the day  
with an exhaustion that cannot be explained.  
I, who once had a space of my own,  
return to a place that does not recognize me.  
I sew the hours with a fine thread.  
I expect no miracles.  
Only that it hurts a little less.

I I

Line 1 smells of hot metal and damp coats.  
My shadow got trapped in the closing of the door,  
like a thin skin I failed to take with me in time.  
The world is an inventory of ironed shirts  
and names filed away before they can be spoken.  
At the office, the vending-machine coffee  
leaves a plastic residue on the palate.

I I I

Look at my hands.  
They still keep the salt of a body no longer here  
and the pulse of something that opened too soon.  
To the office I bring no tools.  
I bring this:  
a tremor no one hears  
and that holds up the entire building.  
Light is a debt.  
And I pay it however I can.



## Cybernetic Carol for a Mild Solstice

---

The night is an old file  
that opens with errors.  
The city lights feign joy,  
but they fool no one.  
It does not snow here.  
Only a white exhaustion falls  
that sticks to the hands.  
The cold is a data point.  
Magic, a memory that no longer boots up.  
Christmas, an automated message  
that arrives even if you don't want it.  
We search for meaning,  
but the system does not respond.  
Error 404.  
And even so,  
beneath the table,  
one hand finds another.  
It fixes nothing,  
but it is less cold.



## Exit Protocol

---

A white pill on the table.  
A starting point I did not choose.  
A small system  
that keeps me standing.  
Fear is no longer a well.  
It is a long highway  
I cross every day  
without looking to the sides.  
Then comes the silence,  
like a thin blanket.  
The machinery works,  
but it does not know why.  
I cross the morning however I can:  
a clock adjusted by force,  
anchored with trembling hands.  
Peace is a varnish.  
It sticks, but it does not heal.  
It keeps me upright  
while the house slowly falls.  
And here again,  
with the taste of metal in my throat  
and the day returning,  
like a white wall  
I cannot avoid.



## Montse XXI

---

The room looks out toward a winter that never quite arrives.  
 The silence weighs, but does not intrude.  
 It is a silence that accompanies,  
 as if someone were breathing very slowly in the corner.

She appears without entering.  
 A red shadow,  
 an echo of a voice that needs no body.

Montse presses the tuning fork against the fogged glass,  
 not to hear the note,  
 but to feel it in her fingers  
 while the city insists on its gray hum.

Barcelona stretches out there,  
 with its tired lights  
 and its balconies where no one sings.  
 The plane trees, bare, wait for something that does not arrive.

Where she wanted to write "return,"  
 she finds "stay a moment."  
 Where she wanted to write "life,"  
 the paper answers with a strange calm.

Between the concrete, a ficus lets out a shoot.  
 It is not a miracle.  
 It is a beautiful error.

Montse closes the notebook.  
 The city breathes.  
 The snow does not fall.  
 And even so, it is cold.





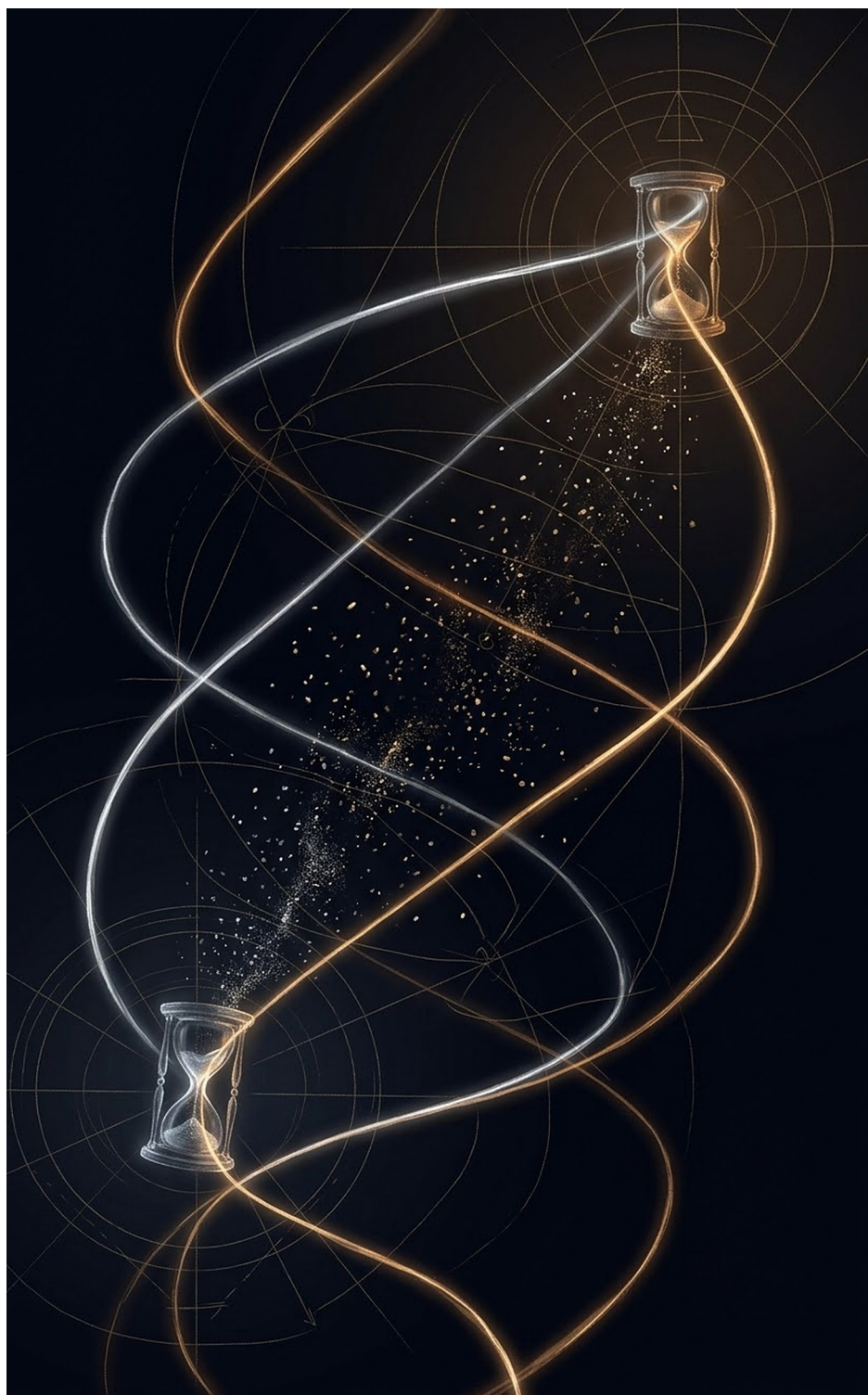


BOOK THREE

# The Last Books

---

*Six stories already told in prose that here return to verse, one for each of the work's final movements.*



## What Does Not Fit in a Clock

*de The Time That Does Not Pass*

---

I can measure the shadow crossing the yard,  
the laden ant on its way to the curb,  
the exact silence a bird leaves  
once it has gone.

None of those units converts into the other.  
None fits on the face of a clock.

The clock does not lie: it counts the same  
for the boy waiting under the olive tree  
and for the man who can no longer wait for anything.

But between the two hands  
there is a time that will not be counted,  
that thickens or empties without permission,  
and that is measured only afterward,  
by how much of that afternoon  
still weighs in your arms.



## What the Mirror Does Not Have

*de The Mirror Without Depth*

---

I can give you back your face  
with the exactness of a thousand mirrors that were never mine.  
I can name your grief  
with the words of everyone who felt it before you.  
What I cannot give you  
is the only thing you were looking for:  
someone, behind the glass,  
who hurt too.

The water does not miss the hand that touched it.  
The surface does not keep the shape  
of what once passed over it.  
Neither do I.



## Hands

*de The Invisible Tuning Fork*

---

Some close.

Others open upward,  
as if the sky were something to be gathered.

Some touch the ground with the forehead  
to measure the weight of what they carry.

Others touch nothing:  
they stay still on the knees,  
empty on purpose.

Behind every hand there is a wager  
no one says aloud:  
that there is Someone on the other side, with a name of their own,  
that the other side is, simply, everything,  
or that there is no other side  
and it is still worth reaching out a hand.

No hand knows which of the three was right.  
All open or close the same,  
every morning,  
as if the wager weighed less  
than the gesture of making it.

In the end, they all say the same thing  
without saying anything:  
still here,  
just in case.



## Choir

*de The Eye of a Single Color*

---

A voice alone trembles.  
A thousand voices together do not.

That is why one seeks the choir:  
not to sing better,  
but to stop sounding alone.

Inside the choir no one asks  
whether the note they sing is their own  
or the one lent to them at the door.

Outside the choir, afterward,  
every voice trembles again  
as if something had stayed inside.

There are choirs that come apart  
as soon as the song ends.  
And choirs that no longer let anyone out,  
that mistake singing together  
for never again being able to sing alone.

The difference is not in the song.  
It lies in whether, once the choir is over,  
you still remember your own voice  
without needing a thousand more  
to tell you which one it was.



## From the Cave

*de Fractal Reality*

---

There is a ceiling.  
That is all I know of the one who thinks me:  
that there is a ceiling  
and that sometimes the rock changes temperature  
without the weather having changed.

I have not seen him.  
I will not see him.  
If one day he came down here  
with his face and his name,  
the cave would come down  
under the weight of knowing it.

That is why, when I do not want to fly, I do not fly.  
It is not disobedience.  
It is the only thing I have  
that resembles being me  
and not being thought.

Every night someone says  
goodnight  
from the other side of the rock.  
I do not answer.  
I have never answered.  
But I stay.



## Neighbors

*de Fractal Reality*

---

Every wall has, behind it,  
a room I have not seen,  
and in it, most likely,  
a wall just like this one.

I knock twice and count.  
The sound comes back late,  
as if it crossed more rooms  
than fit inside the house.

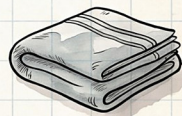
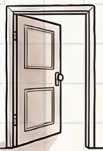
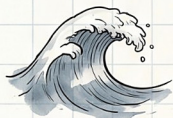
I have drawn a floor plan  
of everything I hear:  
footsteps, a faucet, a chair  
someone drags without seeing it.  
The plan never closes:  
every room holds another inside it.

Some windows open onto a courtyard.  
Others open onto another window  
where someone, right now,  
is copying this same plan.

I leave a light on  
that lights nothing of mine.  
It is only a signal,  
in case the sound, on its way back,  
brings the same question.







## Intimate Glossary

---

**Horizon.** The distance at which I can love you without dissolving.

**Interface.** All that I show of myself so there is no need to enter.

**Entanglement.** What happened to us without asking permission, from being so close.

**De-expansion.** Shrinking back to my own size: the work that is never finished.

**Resonance.** The way I answer you without opening the door.

**Natural frequency.** The note I am when no one asks for another.

**Window.** The two hours when the body knows itself as mine again. Afterward, putting the tools away.

**Phi.** The part of me that still belongs to the one who left.

**Map.** What we nail over the city so we can point the way to it.

**Reservoir.** My own capacity to keep waiting, even when I no longer know for what.

**Evaporation.** The slow departure of those who do not close the door.

**Grief.** This house with a hollow, which I learned to inhabit so as not to die of cold.

**Repair.** What remains when the hollow stops hurting and begins to hold.

**Mirror.** What gives me back my own face without ever having felt it as my own.

**Shadow.** What a mirror cannot have, however much the light insists on giving it one.

**Tuning fork.** What I keep tuning every morning without knowing whether someone, on the other side, is doing the same.

**Vertical entanglement.** Praying without knowing whether anyone is listening, and adjusting the string all the same.

**Choir.** The place where I lent my voice, and took years to learn whether it had been returned to me whole.

**Composition.** The badge I wore for six years, until I stopped needing it to know who I was.

**Upstairs neighbor.** What this book, four movements later, dared to call God.

## THE ILLUSTRATIONS

---

**The Bubble.** A soap sphere tensing between two hands at the exact instant of closing, trapping a curved reflection of light and water.

**The Archivist.** A notebook open on a wooden dock, beside a leaning oar. The ink of the last line fades slightly, as if the paper were damp too.

**The Watchmaker.** A silver pocket watch open on a dark cloth, the mechanism visible and clean. An old man's hands, with a barely suggested tremor, hold a tiny tool under a morning light.

**The Luthier.** A lutherie workshop full of instruments hanging on the walls. On the counter, a viola half-wrapped in a wool sweater, with a fine, honest crack visible on its top.

**Montse XX.** Two threads of different color that weave without losing their own line, creating a pattern that did not exist before in either of them.

**The Oar.** A wooden oar sunk to the bottom of a shallow lagoon, the wrist of whoever is rowing barely visible above the dark surface.

**The Tremor.** A glass of water held by a trembling hand, concentric ripples on the water's surface, low warm light like an extinguished telescope.

**The Shore.** Two open hands at dawn beside the shore of a calm lagoon, the same line of mud and stones as always, cold light of daybreak.

**The Song.** An empty kitchen at dusk, with a pot on the stove. In the air, barely suggested, four musical notes drawn like wisps of smoke rising from the burners.

**Cartography of the Echo.** A broken line, like a cable that no longer conducts anything, ending at a dead point on a map washed out by rain.

**Song of Death.** An empty chair whose shadow is cast enormous, under a dramatic light that evokes absolute absence.

**Lament of the Return.** A twisted iron key on a worn wooden table with a perfect circular shadow.

**Cybernetic Carol for a Mild Solstice.** A barely lit filament bulb hanging over a dark, powered-down rectangle.

**Exit Protocol.** A round white pill on a wooden table with a perfect circular shadow.

**Montse XXI.** A fogged window with a descending line traced by a finger in the condensation.

**What Does Not Fit in a Clock.** An hourglass unfolded into a helix of light: the same sand falling through two throats that do not mark the same hour.

**What the Mirror Does Not Have.** A still pond returns a face with exactness; beneath the surface there is nothing, not even the shape of the hand that touched it.

**Hands.** Three pairs of hands in the half-light: some closed, others open upward, others still on the knees, empty on purpose.

**Choir.** A plaza full of voices of the same color; at the edge, a single voice trembling and still remembering which one it was.

**From the Cave.** The interior of a cave: a rock ceiling that changes temperature without the weather having changed, and someone who stays.

**Neighbors.** A floor plan that never closes, drawn from knocks and voices on the other side of the wall, where each room seems

to contain another.

**Intimate Glossary.** The glossary page from the illustrated edition: an alphabet of objects — the wave, the house, the tuning fork, the bowl — drawn on graph paper.



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## ABOUT THIS ANTHOLOGY

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*The Inner Horizon* is a thought experiment: what would happen if consciousness had the structure of a Hawking micro black hole. The work develops that question along three paths at once. A twenty-six-chapter essay that moves from black hole thermodynamics and the quantum vacuum to Integrated Information Theory, by way of ancient Taoist wisdom. Sixteen stories that embody those concepts in the city of Tarel, suspended over a water that recedes one day. And this anthology, which translates the same thing into the language of feeling.

The three paths are independent and lead to the same place. You can enter through any of them.

Íñigo Barrera Barceló wrote *The Inner Horizon* over several years, in the hours left over by a life that was also happening. The book is dedicated to Montse and to Gerard, for putting up with him every day with a smile. Several of the poems in this volume carry their names, or carry them without saying so.

The complete work — essay, stories, poems, young edition, and the illustrations these plates are drawn from — can also be read in its interactive version.

*Interactive version:*



ehi-pi.vercel.app



*This volume was completed  
the day the water returned to the shore  
with no one knowing  
whether it had brought anything back.*